

Cite as: Pérez Rastrilla, L. (2021). A Proposal for a Qualitative Analysis of the Media Discourse on the Bombing of Yugoslavia. In: Radeljić, B., González-Villa, C. (eds.) *Researching Yugoslavia and its Aftermath. Societies and Political Orders in Transition*. Springer, Cham, pp. 205-222. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-70343-1_10

A PROPOSAL FOR A QUALITATIVE ANALYSIS OF THE MEDIA DISCOURSE ON THE BOMBING OF YUGOSLAVIA

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1. Introduction

In this chapter I will present the analysis framework that I developed during my doctoral thesis for the study of media discourses on the 1999 bombing of Yugoslavia (Pérez Rastrilla, 2017). I will explain the procedure followed, with a detailed account of the steps and some examples of the results obtained. The research carried out was framed within the studies of communication and propaganda and aimed to know the strategies and narrative techniques that legitimised the representation of the bombing of Yugoslavia in the Spanish media.

Some works prioritise the narrative perspective in the study of the disintegration of Yugoslavia and they were useful as a reference. Jin Yang conducted research on the coverage of the Kosovo conflict in the Chinese press, resorting to framing as a methodological framework (Yang, 2003: 231–249). Especially influential were the works of Lene Hansen and Alice Krieg-Planque. The research of the two professors focuses on the conflict in Bosnia. In the case of *Security as Practice* (2006), Hansen analyzes the discourses that circulated during the Bosnian war, approaching them from the US foreign policy. Krieg-Planque (2003) devotes all her attention to a single designation: *ethnic purification*, on which she investigates its genealogy, connotations and uses. To this end, she provides a detailed operationalisation of the term's analysis, which enables the reader to trace the exact path followed by the professor.

When I started the project, the first decision was to carry out a qualitative analysis. The reason is that in the framework of propaganda it is necessary to examine the relationship of ideas, concepts, evocations and the development of reasoning. The researcher must go beyond the mere frequency of the explicit designations in the documents. Occasionally, I resorted to techniques of quantitative analysis, reducing them to those in which frequency is relevant, such as reiteration.

The main challenge at the beginning of the research arose with the search for a qualitative methodology of discursive practices, where I found obstacles. The theoretical frameworks and the subsequent methodologies tended to restrict the analysis of the cases to a very specific dimension. Thus, for example, I found methodologies for the analysis of major ideological frameworks, such as framing. However, they seemed to be completely different from the analysis of micro levels, such as semantic approaches (van Dijk, 1984, 1993, 2005) or the review of linguistic units (Krieg-Planque, 2003). My aim was to be able to investigate the manifestation of the event in the Spanish media from different levels of analysis, as I considered them to be interconnected levels that constituted a single event. For this purpose, there was no uniform or clearly systematised methodology. While linguistic studies were limited to the analysis of certain expressions or words, the exploration of discourses from a perspective of power handled terms such as dominance or hegemony, which lacked operationalisation and procedures to provide analytical units.

This gap forced me to build my own model of analysis, coherent with the research question, integrated into the theoretical perspective and providing accurate analysis tools. At the same time, it had to be an analysis framework that would allow identifying how broader concepts are articulated, in order to understand the material evidence of the studied event. In other words, the ultimate goal of the research was to be able to respond, through the analysis of the representation of the event in the media discourse, to how the bombing was legitimated in the specific way in which it took place.

2. Object of Study

The investigation addressed the media coverage in Spain of the NATO bombing of Yugoslavia between 24 March 1999 and 10 June 1999. Spain was a NATO member state and Javier Solana's position as NATO Secretary-General boosted the Spanish media interest in the bombing. However, Spain's participation in the armed action was notable for its difficult balance, which was marked by domestic issues. One of the cornerstones was that territorial and identity-related tensions made it easier to associate the Kosovo conflict with the Spanish situation. These factors led both national and local media to invest a large number of resources in covering the crisis, with several correspondents and special correspondents in the area. In the research, published texts in four newspapers and information pieces broadcast on two television programmes were analysed. The number of newspapers analysed and the specific headlines were selected according to a wide representation of the ideological spectrum in Spain and to the highest circulation rates in 1999. The reviewed newspapers were *El País*, *El Mundo*, *La Vanguardia* and *ABC*.

The difficulty of studying television material—due to restricted access by the networks and the high economic costs involved—forced me to reduce the number of examined television channels to two. The first one was the Spanish national television (*Televisión Española-TVE*). The selection criteria were based on the significant resources available to public television, as well as the high audience ratings for *Televisión Española* news

broadcasts at the studied period of time. The second station was *Telemadrid* and it was selected on two grounds. On the one hand, its status as a public and local television station. The nature of the conflict raised a great deal of interest among the local Spanish media. As pointed out above, in light of the identity tensions in Spain, the media were trying to show their own version of the Kosovo conflict. On the other hand, when selecting *Telemadrid*, Teresa Aranguren's work in Belgrade as a correspondent during nearly all the bombing period was considered. All the other television stations in Spain were unable to send correspondents into Serbia for such a long period, as many correspondents were expelled in the days before the bombing or arrived much later.

The general approach of the research was to find out about the hegemonic story of the Kosovo conflict in the Spanish media, that is, the lines of reasoning that circulated in the Spanish media, how it was constructed and why that specific story took place. The aim was to explore what keys to the international, ideological and geopolitical framework of a given moment could be obtained through the analysis of the narrative of a specific event. The theoretical framework and the research questions meant that the object of study was much broader than the discourses that circulated in the Spanish media during the studied period. Thus, the corpus of analysis was also comprised of those documents that were a reference in the construction of the media discourse between March and June 1999.

A review of these types of documents was carried out according to the sources. Thus, in addition to media texts, the analysis was also conducted on documents of a political and military nature, issued by NATO, the United States government, governments of any of the Alliance member states, the United Nations or other public institutions. A third group of studied narratives consisted of sources different from the previous ones, such as NGOs, unofficial information and accounts of witnesses to the events, including journalists themselves. A fourth and final set of analysed documents comprised face-to-face interviews with the tellers of the narratives, such as journalists and NATO staff. On these documents, the previous knowledge that the speech producers had acquired about the region—through cultural representations such as books or films, personal experiences and past media and political accounts—was investigated, as well as the memory of the bombing-related stories and the professional practice of interviewees. The research questions were presented in three groups according to the area of study. The first group was concerned with the theoretical- methodological framework. The second addressed the analysis of the narrative in media and political texts. Finally, the third one was formulated around the international framework of the studied event. Although practical examples resulting from the analysis of the documents will be provided throughout the chapter, it primarily focuses on the steps followed in order to answer the first block of questions, which started from the premise that political discourse is inherent to political action and inquired about the mechanisms of analysis that can be developed to allow us to understand power relations through their expression in discourse.

3. A Methodology for a Theoretical Framework

The focus on discursive practices was a significant advance in the comprehension of the use of power. From the point of view of *critical theory*, discourse is regarded as a substantial component of power. Naming the *discourse* is intended to differentiate it from the power that structuralist theories label as *material*, thus distinguishing it from communication or propaganda. This framework was considered the most appropriate for answering the question from which this research arises, but it does not imply opposition or rejection of structuralist theories or the methods of analysis they propose. In recent decades, the confrontation between supporters of structuralist approaches and post-structuralists or critics has buried the link between both theories. While materialist theories provide precise descriptions of power structures, critical theory offers the codes, firstly, about the origin of these structures and, secondly, about the mechanisms that allow them to be sustained, thus covering two gaps in earlier theories. Thus, the research was addressed, as Hansen points out, so that '[t]here is no "extra-discursive" materiality that sets itself forward independently of its discursive representation—which, to reiterate, is not to say that the material has no importance, but rather that it is always discursively mediated' (Hansen, 2006: 22).

2.1. Ideology and Power: Framing

Media discourses are based on identities, values, fears and other elements that do not exist either as tangible elements or as objective facts, but have material consequences through the exercise of power because, as Charaudeau (2002) points out, 'discourse analysis does not question either the good foundation of political rationality or the mechanisms that produce this or that political behaviour, but rather the discourses that make possible both the emergence of political rationality and the regulation of political facts.' In order to articulate this theoretical framework and outline the steps leading to empirical work, critical theory, poststructuralism and postmodernism (Bourdieu, 1991; Derrida, 1978; Foucault, 2012; Habermas, 1996) have made use of various concepts that, whilst not equivalent, do allude to the same gears of power, such as ideology, normalisation or hegemony. However, the problem I found at the beginning of the research process is that none of them served as an analytical category, since they are such broad and ambiguous concepts with an overwhelming amount of meanings and projections. Therefore, their delimitation was an essential preliminary step before operationalisation.

In the research, ideology was defined as the set of ideas and precepts that promote political action, that is, searching for a manifestation in action. Ideology was also understood in relation to the field of a social conflict substantial to the political, configured through signs, representations and signifiers:

Ideologies are the basic frameworks for organising the social cognitions shared by members of social groups, organisations or institutions. In this respect, ideologies are both cognitive and social. They essentially function as the interface between the

cognitive representations and processes underlying discourse and action, on the one hand, and the societal position and interests of social groups, on the other hand. (van Dijk, 2005: 17–18)

I deemed that the most appropriate tool for the recognition of these dominant ideological structures was framing. This is the most generic level of analysis, in which the great discourses that constitute the narrative axis of an event are distinguished. Their circulation is measured by their presence in all the dimensions of the event and for the time they are active. In this phase, the universal truths, principles and commonplaces that shape the perception of the world are identified. It is the moment in which ‘the researcher reconstructs the general rules of what can be said and written; a topic, a gnoseology, which systematically determines what is acceptable in the discourse of an epoch’ (Angenot, 2010: 75). Thus, framing identifies the dominant discourses that structure the interpretation of reality, and that hegemonic interpretation is based on incontrovertible or universal ideas (Wallerstein, 2007: 13). These are the internalised norms mentioned by Foucault, which do not have to do with repression, but rather with mechanisms of control accepted as normal (1991: 170; 2012: 151). They are characterised as premises that do not need to be explained or justified, they are internalised; they are part of the knowledge of a community and are those that the community itself calls common sense, which makes them one of the most powerful rhetorical resources, because ‘the central and most cunning feature of the taken for granted everyday world is that it *is* taken for granted’ (Pollner, 1974: 37).

In the framing analysis of the bombing of Yugoslavia in the Spanish media, four major discursive frameworks were identified. A discourse of fear, based on the expansion of the war scenario to the United States and the rest of Europe in the event of non-intervention in the conflict; the discourse of genocide, based on the configuration of the identities of the conflicting sides as a generalisation between active and passive agents; a discourse of an identity-based nature, which defined relations between the Balkans and the West¹ in a hierarchical order; and, finally, the discourse of humanitarian intervention, constituted by the moral obligation that the West should apply violent methods to put an end to the violence in the region. The discursive framework of humanitarian interventionism will be observed as an example, which was based on numerous discursive elements, such as moral obligation, civilisational hierarchy, the historical distance between the West and the Muslim communities in the region and the omission of the international legal framework. For reasons of limits of extension, I will focus on some of the discursive elements that brought meaning to the characterisation of the event as humanitarian.

One of the keys to this frame was the representation of violence according to the national origin of the perpetrator. I will show, in particular, the representation of

¹ Throughout the chapter the terminology normally used in the analysed texts will be used and only the exceptions will be indicated. Thus, both the media and the other sources reviewed commonly spoke of the West, when, strictly speaking, they were only referring to NATO. They also often referred to the Balkans as synonymous with Yugoslavia.

Western violence. During the first two weeks of the bombing, the humanitarian nature of the action was justified by the principle of a just war by which only greater damage can justify an attack; that is, Serbia was causing more damage than the NATO bombing could possibly cause: 'the interference is great, because the clamorous brutality that makes it necessary is also great' (*ABC*, 1999b); the bombing was carried out by 'making a deliberate effort to minimise the harm to the innocent' (Clinton & Cohen, 1999); '[t]he bombing of Serbia is being carried out with exquisite care ... will involve a discriminated use of force, which can be defended precisely because it is discriminated' (Woollacott, 1999), '[t]he use of force is always regrettable ... but when horror and nonsense have reached the levels suffered by Kosovo Albanians today, comparisons in suffering become sarcasm' (*El País*, 1999a).

However, within weeks of beginning the armed action, Western violence began to cause significant damage, calling into question proportionality and the principle of a just war. When the bombing began to cause inexplicable destruction to the public in NATO member countries, the organisation spoke of mistakes. However, the key to maintaining the representation of humanitarian action was to give the violence exercised by the West a moral and therefore acceptable burden. This was based on Western good intentions and superiority: 'Not all violence is equally reprehensible' (Sontag, 1999), '[a]s sad as it may be, but it fits in with the developed society' (Sepúlveda, 1999a), '[t]he Allies seek to bomb only military and strategic targets. They sometimes fail... It is the moral difference that counts' (Vidal-Folch, 1999c), '[a]n accident like this is not going to weaken our determination to continue because our cause is just' (Jamie Shea, in *Telemadrid*, 1999b), 'I am horrified to think that there are going to be innocent victims, but the difference is that we do not deliberately shoot defenceless people' (Bauluz, 1999), "[w]e should be proud of what we are doing," stresses Solana' (*Afp & Reuters*, 1999), 'NATO claims that a pilot caused the massacre by firing in "good faith"' (Segovia, 1999b).

Moral superiority led to the obligation to teach Serbia how to behave, even if it entailed pain. Thus, it was not contradictory to speak of humanitarian action, despite being violent; as if it were a medicine that tastes bad but cures, the violent means and victims caused by NATO were represented as beneficial and positive for that country: 'Such regrettable but necessary facts' (Trías Sagnier, 1999), '[i]t is possible that the bombs falling on Saddam Hussein's or Milošević's backs are healthy' (Campany, 1999), '[t]he Serbian society could not be insensitive to a peaceful invitation of one hundred million people' (Fisas, 1999), '[b]ombings to give them the unsurpassable gift of peace' (López Sancho, 1999), '[t]he Serbian people must wake up. That is what NATO bombs are for' (*ABC*, 1999a), '[a] woman described the noise of NATO aircraft engines as "the sound of angels"' (Lévy, 1999).

The humanitarian framework was also maintained through the omission of information. NATO avoided talking about the damage it was causing and made efforts to control the direction of media perceptions in the headquarters in Brussels by, for example, marking what events were discussed, what kinds of actions were violent, what response was made to violent events, what was the meaning of justice and from what moment peace could be addressed. Finally, the omission of damage, which helped to maintain the image of humanitarian action, was also achieved through the

representation of violence ‘as an entertaining and recreational activity, replete with good humour, friendship and sports competition ... which helps to reduce the horrors of war’ (Čolović, 1993: 117–118). The following examples illustrate this idea: ‘[Humanitarian intervention is] a great adventure’ (Bernard Kouchner, in Rieff, 1999: 219), ‘[a]ccording to Major Simon, we do not consider ourselves to be at war. We are participating in a mission aimed at pacifying Kosovo. In this sense, we do not live in a warlike atmosphere’ (Boo, 1999), ‘I too am deeply impressed by the solidarity of NATO’s purpose’ (Clinton, 1999a), and the story of this pilot interviewed in Aviano: ‘It’s a lot of fun. I love my job... It’s like playing a video game and riding a roller coaster at the same time’ (Knightley, 2003: 507).

3.2. The Heartbeat of Texts: Intertextuality

The second step in the construction of the analysis model is based on the assumption that ‘all discourses are historical and can therefore only be understood with reference to their context’ (Michael Meyer, in Wodak & Meyer, 2001: 15). This notion implies that media discourse is produced by individuals, who are immersed in the structure of the media and its implications—editorial line, work routines, economic dependencies and access to certain sources—that also exist and operate in other, broader contexts. Many discourses that circulate in it have shaped the subjectivity of the journalist. The tool that critical theory has at its disposition to access all these levels is intertextuality, as formulated by Julia Kristeva (1980).

Intertextuality means that all texts are placed in a wider scope than the text itself, as they are constructed with references to other documents, quotations or examples. Thus, this tool investigates the path of the political meaning of the analysed concept, of its dominant position and into the shaping of identities. Through intertextuality, the permanent historical dialectic between the stories of the past and the present is deciphered, and we learn how the projections of the future are justified. And to do so, we walk the path of legitimacy, investigating the seeding of the representation of discourse. Because of this, intertextuality should not be reduced to the specific discursive space where analysed narratives circulate. Since discourses do not remain in cubicles preserved from the influence of other discourses, either in space or in time, the scope of research must be broadened (Kristeva, 1980: 36). Lene Hansen emphasises this feature in her analysis of US foreign policy during the Bosnian war and stresses the need to access as many different documents as possible in order to understand all dimensions of the event (Hansen, 2006: 7, 131). Political, magical, legal, academic and vulgar issues—from the past and in the present—although not always explicitly cited, are all crossed more or less conspicuously in composing the dominant narratives. For this reason, intertextuality analysis implies knowing deeply the object of study’s context and the historical story, which is retrieved at the analysed period of time.

What is popularly referred to as historical legacy plays a key role in intertextuality. It is not only essential to be familiar with the past of the conflict studied (or the dominant official version), but also with the multiple reinterpretations of that past, which have

circulated in different historical spaces and moments, the discourse components of the conflict, as well as those that have been erased:

A historical legacy cannot be changed, but what we can do is either evoke it or conceal it, glorify or taboo it, depending on our present aspirations. Historical legacies are continually reinterpreted and used by countries sharing them to vindicate contemporary collective identities and political and social strategies. "Ordinary people" and members of political elites and institutions are both included in this process. (Petrović, 2009: 57)

The result is an interaction between texts on which continuity is built, a history of the legitimisation of texts, concepts and designations. Consequently, intertextuality denies a static dimension of ideas or the pretension of giving them a date of birth. A notion or a text referred to at a given moment does not preserve the identity of its original conception, but rather over time it has been interpreted, redefined, crossed by other ideas and faced with contradictions. All of that is determined by the specific political context in which it is used. 'Thus, (the discourses) contribute to the structuring of the power relations in a society' (Siegfried Jäger, in Wodak & Meyer, 2001: 37).

Sample results that illustrate the application of intertextuality analysis, in the Kosovo case, include the text published by the Carnegie Endowment, in 1914, which was reprinted in 1994, to justify the impossibility of change in the region due to ancestral hatreds and, consequently, the ineffectiveness of foreign intervention. This discourse coexisted with those in favour of armed intervention, who recalled the First World War as a result of the conflicts in the Balkans and the danger of its extension to the rest of Europe.

In the latter instance, the narrative was constructed years after the war among the great powers. With this story they concealed their responsibility for the outbreak of the Great War: 'to be doing this in the place where the First World War began' (Clinton, 1999b), '[i]n that exploding region, which has set old Europe on fire twice, is likely to cause serious problems for the whole EU' (San Sebastián, 1999), '[m]any of the arguments we are discussing these days are very similar to those discussed in 1914' (Foix, 1999a), '[t]he twentieth century, a century of many totalitarian follies, a century of Auschwitz and the Gulag, began with the Balkan War and ends with another war in the Balkans' (Michnik, 1999), '[t]he First World War. Austrian Archduke Franz Ferdinand and his wife were killed by a Serbian nationalist... Could history repeat itself?' (Porcel, 1999b), 'the twentieth century began in Sarajevo, the twenty-first century will also begin' (Sontag, 1999), '[i]n the Balkans the shortest century began ... to conclude, once again, in the Balkans' (Fuentes, 1999), '[n]ever forget that it was not by chance that the First World War started in this area. There are ancestral hatreds that obsess people and lead them to horrible abuses' (Clinton, 1993, in Hansen, 2006: 121).

In the two previous examples, the texts and events were explicitly mentioned, but the intertextuality is also more subtly manifested so that the reference to the sources is not named. As an example, one of the most interesting discursive elements found in the

research is the denial of the Albanian community as an active political actor. It is striking that, in the representation of the crisis, despite being a conflict of secession, there is no politically active independentist community. To understand this absence, we have to dip into the historical relationship between the great European empires and the Balkan region. Throughout the crisis and up to the present day, this association has been marked by a hierarchical relationship, based on the developmental and civilisational classification applied to all Balkan peoples. But in the representation of the Albanian Kosovars, in addition to the civilising discourse, it is necessary to add elements of the romantic discourse, which is partly based on religious antagonism. Let us see how it was expressed in the discourse of the 1990s.

The image of the inferiority of the Orthodox faith prevailed during the disintegration of Yugoslavia in the media. However, such representation coexisted in tension with the residues of the discourse of Christian unity before the Muslim communities. In this sense, the alliance between the West and the Kosovar Albanian community was a turning point in the relationship between both, and responded to the political interests of the moment. From the mid-nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, the discourse on the liberation of Christian peoples from the yoke of the Ottoman Empire raised barriers between the Balkan peoples and it fostered different degrees of identity between them. In this process, religion was crucial. Islam became a decisive factor for the European powers to identify the Albanian community as the enemy. In Western representations, Albanians embodied the opposite values of the brave and heroic Christian Serbs, Greeks or Montenegrins (Jezernik, 2004: 86–87). This discourse, in turn, was internalised and reproduced by local political movements.

Despite the effort to provide a positive image of the Kosovo Albanian community and its military alliance with NATO, the narrative of alienation between the West and the Kosovo Albanian community was often echoed in the conflicts of the 1990s. As with the other Balkan communities of the former Yugoslavia, the West positioned itself as an indispensable supervisor of Kosovo. But the description of the Kosovo Albanian community went beyond civilisational discourse. For example, despite the transitional political alliance, disparaging narratives with religious overtones were common.² Thus, even with the stated intention of defending the Kosovo Albanian community, the media published descriptions on Kosovar Albanians that were not applied to other communities on the peninsula, not even to the Serbian enemy. Depictions were on the verge of contempt and xenophobia and they described behaviours among Albanians closer to the fifteenth century than to the majority social dynamics in the region at the end of the 1990s: ‘The Kosovars are not exactly like us’ (Ortiz, 1999), ‘[t]he Albanians are a population that belongs to the European world, but maintains a unique character ... of the Muslim religion, they discriminate women, and they are used only for

² Alice Krieg-Planque found in the Western narratives of Bosnian women degrees of otherness features very similar to those identified in the Kosovo crisis narrative, where the civilisation discourse clashes with specific political interests. For example, the military alliance with the Muslims from Bosnia-Herzegovina was justified on the grounds of their closeness to European culture and their secularism. However, when rapes were reported, emphasis was placed on how particularly humiliating they were for Bosnian Muslim women because of their religion and conservative culture (Krieg-Planque, 2003).

reproduction' (Vasijevic, 1999), 'some Albanian criminals stole my money at gunpoint. This unpleasant experience is, however, part of Albanian folklore' (Masle, 1999: 411), '[t]aking away an Albanian's gun is almost impossible, as well as dangerous considering that they have gone to several wars to defend their right to carry them' (Pučnik, 1999), 'the shoes, are set in the Muslim way, always in the hall'³ (Juliana, 1999a), 'among Kosovar Albanians ... the eastern taste of gunpowder and homemade weapons' (Fernández Elorriaga, 1983), '[w]hen President Clinton asked for the nation's support for the bombing of Kosovo, the Americans had some questions. Is this in Europe? Or is it the name of a local gas station?' (CNN, 1999 in Caforio, 2000: 95), 'historically Albanians are stubborn, but not upright. Well-driven, they are obedient and have never risen, except in the face of two frequent offenses: the military one, of trying to disarm and recruit them; and the family one, of looting the house and confronting his wife... Their irredentism coexists with a lack of nationalism and self-esteem' (Villapadierna, 1999b), 'recalcitrant Kosovars' (Nadal, 28 February 1999), 'the typical Albanian face, wide forehead, sharp chin, pointed nose and an old suspicious look' (Juliana, 1999b), 'I am interested in these Kosovars, Albanians or whatever they are' (I. F. Arias, 1999), '[h]ow Albanian witches cure with onions... This is Kosovo and this is how Albanians are' (López Schlichting, 1999).

This romantic discourse, which described the Albanian community negatively because of its differences with the West and Serbia itself, was also common in the Spanish military institutions: 'The Spanish military's teaching handbook on Kosovo ... is more in tune with the Serbs... The Albanian, the text says, is "traditionally- minded" and is "sober, long-suffering and vindictive." He is "distrustful and critical" and is always against the established authority, "whether Albanian or foreign..." The KLA is described as a "terrorist organisation," ... the Serbs are "tough, motivated and highly disciplined fighters, respectful of power and not very conflictive," "loyal in their commitments" but "very nationalistic and discriminatory towards other races"' (González, 1999).

Another expression of the disregard for the Kosovar Albanian people, despite the political agreement, was the absence of the representation of their history. Instead, the media followed the narrative pattern of the peak acceptance of Christian unity in the nineteenth century. Everything that could be obtained from the political and media discourses of the 1990s on the history of the Kosovar Albanian community was based on its relationship with Serbia and its impact on the Serbian community.

Western political opportunism and the legacy of the romantic discourse made the analysis of the representation of the Kosovar Albanian community extremely complex. In the case of the Spanish media, we should add the influence of the domestic political factor. The potential identification of the Kosovo crisis with the territorial conflict in Spain led to the political identity of the Kosovar Albanians being undermined with particular emphasis. Aspirations of independence were thus completely omitted; it was impossible to find the statements made openly by KLA spokesmen about their resolve

³ Such expressions also denote a certain lack of knowledge about the culture of the region. In all the republics of the former Yugoslavia there is a custom to take off the shoes at the entrance of any home, from Slovenia to Macedonia, regardless of religion. It is also customary in Russia and the Nordic States.

to pay any price to achieve independence.⁴ The result was the representation of the Kosovo Albanian community as a homogeneous society, without history and, above all, exclusively as victims; the Kosovo Albanians were dependent subjects, always in need for protection and without the capacity to act as politically active agents.

3.3. Persuasion Through the Microscope: Rhetoric as a Technique of Analysis

To complete discourse analysis it was necessary to descend from the concepts of ideology, power and intertextuality to a much more concrete and tangible level of microanalysis. This was achieved through the work on language.

In the research, language was considered as an inevitably ideological tool that shapes the visions that we have of the world, marking priorities, impositions and hierarchies; that is, as an instrument in the construction of dominance relations. From this approach, the study of a pure language, marked only by the biological capacity of human beings to communicate, differentiated from the usage language, is impossible, as Pierre Bourdieu pointed out (1991: 39). It would be fruitless to eliminate the social conditions in which a language is generated and acquired. In Shapiro's terms, 'language is not a transparent tool functioning as a medium for the registration of data ... but a field of social and political practice, and hence there is no objective or "true meaning" beyond the linguistic representation to which can refer' (Shapiro, 1981: 16). Based on this logic, a micro-level of analysis could be related to intertextuality and framing. In the operationalisation of this association, the first step was to identify observable categories that could be analysed (Calabrese, 2007; Krieg-Planque, 2003). With the aim that the model of analysis could be applied to the investigation of any other case of armed conflict, the suggestion was to work with three general observable categories: events, places and actors.

It is important to note that the study of the representation of these categories must go beyond the mere quantitative analysis. The number of times an actor is cited, for example, does not provide any relevant information. In this case, it would be an analysis limited to a single rhetorical form, i.e. reiteration. For this reason, it is essential to know the circulation and specific interpretation of that actor. It is not a question of recording the times that the actor is quoted, but of paying attention to the meaning of a discourse issued at a specific time and in a specific space. Likewise, one must observe not only

⁴ Adem Demaçi, Hashim Thaçi and Bardhyl Mahmuti made statements in this regard, to mention some examples. The latter stated in an interview in 1998 that: 'It is the KLA the one that has started the war. The Yugoslav army has not started armed operations against people who were quietly at home, that does not stand. It was in the attempt to destroy the KLA militants, like Adem Jashari, that the Serbs attacked and everything started... Today, almost every day, about ten Serbs are killed. Hundreds of soldiers and policemen have been killed, there have been a hundred times more people killed than in the official figures. We will use all tactics to push the Serbs into a bad position' (Mahmuti, 1999: 136, 183).

the exact designations but also all the possible variations under which the same category is referred to.

Once the observable categories have been established, they are placed in a context (already addressed in the framing and intertextuality phases) to continue to explore the interpretative mechanisms of language that allow us to recognise the categories and name them in a specific way. Rhetoric thus becomes a useful tool with which evocations, images and representations of these categories of analysis can be identified, both in form and content. The implementation of rhetorical analysis is carried out by identifying rhetorical resources such as metaphors, ellipses, euphemisms, epithets, antitheses, synecdoches or repetitions,⁵ to mention some of the multiple manifestations of language.

I will illustrate this level of analysis by resorting to the use of euphemisms. For example, 'the bombing,' as an event, and all the actions and consequences associated with it were represented in such a way as to avoid transmitting violence, material damage or murder and to evoke the image of a beneficial and supportive action. Thus, the violence of the bombings was camouflaged in synonyms, such as 'air campaign' or 'air operation' (*Telemadrid*, 1999c), a 'hit to the television' (Villapadierna, 1999c), 'pressing the button' (Vidal-Folch, 1999a), 'a strong message' (Vidal-Folch, 1999b), 'execute the operational plans' (Villapadierna, 1999a), 'limited attack' (Cuna, 1999), 'punishment operation' (Larraya & González, 1999), to 'do the job' (Wilby, 1999), to 'clean up' (Segovia, 1999a), 'an increasing pressure' (Chirac, 1999) or the fact that 'we then have married force with diplomacy' (Albright, 1999), "a solemn declaration" not written in ink but in gunpowder' (Barbería, 1999a), 'the "diplomatic" weight of the powerful American B-52s' (Barbería, 1999b), 'air retaliation' (Blanco, 1999), 'NATO's bellicose pressure' (Montano, 1999), 'H time' (*Telemadrid*, 1999a), 'a warlike adventure' (Valenzuela, 1999). The bombers were 'guardian angels' (Fumagalli, 1999) and the aim of the bombings was to 'clear the land' (Vidal-Folch, 1999b). The material damage and injuries caused by the bombing were referred to as 'inconvenient' (Tapia, 1999), 'inexplicable clumsiness' (*ABC*, 1999b), 'incident' (*La Vanguardia*, 1999) or 'the preferred target of allied attacks' (Gumucio, 1999). The fatalities of the Atlantic Alliance's actions appeared in speeches as 'risks worth taking' (Solana, 1999), 'losses' (Valenzuela & Vidal-Folch, 1999), 'mistakes' (*El País*, 1999b), 'collateral damage' (*El Mundo*, 1999b) and 'victims of the so-called friendly fire' (Montano, 1999). The bombing of the Chinese embassy, which killed three people and injured twenty, was called 'a tragic accident' (*CNN*, 1999), 'slip' or 'botched job' (Merry del val et al., 1999).

The use of euphemisms in this sense crosses all levels of analysis and manifests itself both in the framework of humanitarian action, which has been presented as an example at the level of framing analysis, and in rhetorical analysis. The second instance of rhetorical analysis is the use of analogies, such as metaphors and metonymies.

⁵ The referent authors in the list of rhetorical figures have been José Luis García Barrientos (1998), Stefano Arduini (2000), Henri Suhamy (1981) and Perelman and Olbrechts-Tyteca (2009). Two of the best examples of the application of rhetoric to the analysis of political discourses have been the thesis of Aránzazu Capdevila Gómez (2002) and the works of Alexandre Dorna (1993).

Analogies consist of relationships of similarities between several elements that are highly effective, since it is not necessary to develop a new interpretation, but rather to apply that of the referenced elements. In the case of the Kosovo conflict, the most commonly used comparisons referred to past events, such as the First World War (as already discussed at the intertextual level) or the Second World War. Analogies require that the receiver knows the referenced elements and the hegemonic interpretation of it in order for the intended result to be achieved: awakening the emotion, terror or anxiety of returning to a traumatic past. Therefore, it is very common that the elements with which they are compared are of extended knowledge among the receivers.

While analogies can be used with a didactic function, they present risks outside of literary texts. The most remarkable adulteration that any analogy causes is the nullification of the historical context that is represented. They are didactic fallacies because they lead to 'the extraction of specific lessons from one historical situation and the literal application of them to contemporary problems without regard to differences in time, space and circumstances' (Herring, 2000: 356). The deception that hides the analogy is the deformation of the present from past events. Memories, interpretations, even locations of past events are recalled rather than present scenarios, which involves the loss of rigour and precision: 'Because news events are unlikely to follow the direct path of a historical predecessor, the minimisation of cognitive effort by reliance on inferred probability (and its accompanying misrecognition of the manifold possibilities that have yet to occur) means that what is saved in thought is often cost in accuracy' (Bates, 2009: 32).

The simplification to which the analogies lead eliminates the specificities of the new event and reduces two events to one. As Keneth Thompson points out, there is a 'tyranny of the past over the imagination, details and causes are ignored and the produced knowledge is based on generalisations' (Jervis, 2017: 217–218). Let us look at the example of how this kind of rhetorical resource was used in the description of the actors, specifically of Slobodan Milošević, in which it was frequently represented as other political characters, rather than placing him in his specific historical, geographical and political context. The most repeated analogy in the weeks before and during the bombing was the equation of Milošević with historical dictators, especially Adolf Hitler: 'This Serbian dictator, an emulation of Hitler and Stalin at the same time' (Bonino, 6 April 1999), '[h]e belongs to Saddam Hussein's select club' (Garrido Genovés, 1999), 'Milošević is surely an abominable dictator; as abominable perhaps as Hitler was in his day' (Rubio Llorente, 1999), 'Pinochet, Milošević (Gay, 16 April 1999), 'Milošević has a bit of Stalin and a bit of Hitler' (Sentís, 1999), 'Milošević is not Hitler, but he is, as a strategist of political crime, a worthy heir to Stalin' (Elorza, 1999), '[s]ince Hitler and Pol Pot, the responsibility of a genocide had not been personified as much as in Milošević' (Sepúlveda, 1999b), '[t]he Hitlers, the Gaddafi, the Milošević's (Jackson, 1999), 'Slobo is like Saddam. Yes. Unfortunately, the closer we get to the present, the more plausible the analogy is' (Garton Ash, 1999), 'Milošević has, for the first time after Hitler, rehabilitated Nazism' (Dizdjarevic, 1999), '[t]he plans of the criminal Milošević, who has rescued the Nazi methods for razing Kosovo' (*El Mundo*, 1999a), '[t]he Stroessners of the past and the Milošević of the future' (Preciado, 1999), '[l]ike Hitler, Milošević... has propped up a national communist system' (Vidal, 1999), 'this apprentice of Hitler... The "mein kampf" in Milošević's present version' (J. Arias,

1999), 'Slobodan Milošević is a criminal and sadistic madman. Hitler is quoted as a precedent, he was. But Milošević comes directly from Stalin, including the mass murders for national reasons' (Porcel, 1999a), 'Milošević's aggressive intentions were clear from his rhetoric in the 1980s, as were Hitler's in the 1930s' (*RFE/RL*, 2000), 'Milošević's ideas are very similar to Hitler's' (Foix, 1999b).

The analogies also became established with pictures. An article dealing with the figure of Milošević was, in fact, illustrated with a photo of Adolf Hitler (d'Ormesson, 1999). On another occasion, an article entitled 'The "Führer" of the Balkans' was accompanied by two photos, one of Milošević, and a second of Hitler (Solar, 1999). These analogies brought back to life the fear of the European and American imaginary generated by the events that took place in the Second World War. Their use prevented reflection on the specificities of the conflict and 'failed to situate the Yugoslav war in the contemporaneity of its world' (Krieg-Planque, 2003: 165). These representations led to the omission of real Yugoslav affairs and denied rigorous and specific analysis of the figure of Milošević, as any interpretation of Hitler was applicable. At the same time, the political objectives of the Third Reich were projected into the dissolution of Yugoslavia and the history of Kosovo was interpreted in relation to the Germany of the 1930s. The result of this political action was therefore to expect the same responses as in 1939.

4. Conclusion

Discourse analysis allows us to identify power gaps, fears of loss of dominance, structural mechanisms of oppression and paradigm shifts, all of which are very useful in the study of power and its dynamics. However, for such an analysis to be effective, it is essential to have a clearly defined operationalisation.

In the obsession to show each process of analysis as unique and subject to the subjectivity of each researcher, post-structuralist approaches have ended up nullifying the debate, verification and extrapolation of the analyses under the premise of having as many valid analyses as there are researchers. From this postulate, the academy is saturated with studies loaded with prejudices, stereotypes and preconceived ideas defended on the basis of the exceptionality of the researcher. For this reason, in this research, it was considered essential to explain in detail the mechanisms of the implementation of discourse analysis, both the detailed description of the steps taken and the collection of evidence that supports the deductions of frameworks of analysis, such as framing. In this vein, the reader is able to check the steps taken in each stage of the research and, therefore, apply the methodology to the study of other cases. In the presented case study, three interconnected and complementary levels of analysis were established: framing, intertextual analysis and rhetorical analysis as methods and techniques of the undefined framework called discourse analysis.

Moreover, only a transparent operationalisation allows the opening of a debate around the results based on the presentation of new evidence and not on the prejudices or political ideology of the researcher. Thus, both the criticism and the continuation of research must be based on tangible, precise and verifiable results. This approach

requires in-depth knowledge of the context of the object of study, a detailed and extensive reading of the available information, as well as the reformulation of the analysis as the documents become known. In this sense, discourse analysis is a challenge for the researcher, forcing him/her to leave aside any ideological bias, taboo or scruple. Only in this way can the academy become a constructive space that interacts with society and, in short, be useful.

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